

Communion and Foot Washing

Please open to 1 Corinthians 11.

At the beginning of last year, God gave a set of instructions: come to the place, no matter what it takes, where you will not give offense and where you will not become offended yourself.

If I remember the instructions correctly, they were that if you were not there, then make it a point to come to that place, because it is very necessary for the work of God that is in His mind.

But this year, when He came on me the other night, I noticed the instructions were more like this: do not let yourself be taken too far off into offense.

When God opened communion up to me, I found out that in Paul's day the issue was not whether a person could receive healing from God. It was not whether healing was in His will. Those were not the issues in Paul's day. Whether or not God wanted to heal, whether or not healing was in the atonement, whether or not God healed--all the diversities of doctrine we have today--the devil has had time to do a pretty good work.

So that was not the issue. When someone got sick, and in particular when someone died from sickness, there was always a reason.

That is pretty hard to accept, because in our own spirituality and self-exaltation we are willing to give God plenty of reasons:

"You brought this on me to teach me something I could not have learned any other way."

The problem is, if your reasons are not dictated by the Word of God, they do not make sense.

One of the hardest things to face is our own inadequacies, shortcomings, and failures. They are hard to face. But then again, none of them are going to change until you face them.

When somebody got sick, Paul was quick to state the reason why, and that is what he was doing here in communion. In this communion teaching, Paul brought a church full of strife face to face with the communion table so they would judge themselves.

After he brought them face to face with the communion table, there was not a person in that church who did not know they were not supposed to walk in strife. There was not a person who did not know they were coming face to face with accountability for that knowledge when they took communion. They were supposed to judge themselves. No one did not know that.

Look at 1 Corinthians 11:30:

For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep.

"Sickly" means resident diseases had moved into their bodies. We are not talking about the results of aging. We are talking about resident diseases moving in and causing them to die before they lived their life out, or their ministry out.

He said, "For this cause."

Isn't it something that right in the middle of the most Pentecostal chapters--chapter 11, chapter 12 on the gifts of the Spirit, chapter 13 on love--right in the middle of the chapters Pentecostals claim, Paul says, "For this cause many are sick among you"?

One of the most asked questions is, "Why do some people die of disease and some do not? Why does He heal some and not others?"

Kathryn Kuhlman said the first question she was going to ask God was, "Why didn't You heal everybody? Why did You heal some and not others?"

I went on Lester Sumrall's program one time. He had preached at his church and seen how many people were healed that night, and he said, "I want you to go on the program with me in the morning."

So they turned the camera on. That red light came on, and I was trying to look like I knew everything. When Lester found out I did not, he just used me as a bouncing post from then on.

He said, "Brother Roberson, tell me, why does God heal some and not others?"

I did not know. I had an idea, but I thought I would come up with something theological.

I said, "Well, there are as many reasons as there are people sitting in the room."

After I said that, I thought, "I cannot believe you said that."

That is just what he thought too, because from then on he answered all the questions he asked me. I am glad that was a long time ago.

But right here in this Pentecostal chapter, Paul says, "For this cause." He would not say "for this cause" unless there was a cause given somewhere in the chapter. Why say "for this cause" if there was no cause? That is the law of meditation: somewhere in this chapter, he gives you the cause.

Again he says:

For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep.

"Sleep" is a kind word. It means they died. The insinuation is that they died before their time.

But verse 31 says:

For if we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged.

That kind of judgment would not come on us if we judged ourselves.

When we are judged, when we accept judgment--whether we bring it on ourselves by judging ourselves, or whether God's hand lifts and the devil starts beating us up until we see the light and get on our knees and judge ourselves--either way, we come to the place of saying, "This is it. I am not doing this anymore."

Or we die.

Can the doctor keep us alive? I asked God that one time. I said, "If You have lifted Your hand and judgment is on us and we are dying, should we go to the doctor? I might be in great pain. Maybe some cancer is growing out of me and I do not like this pain. Should I go to a doctor? If judgment is on me, You would think God would not want me to go to the doctor. You would think He would want me to take the full meal."

So I asked Him, "Would You want me to go to a doctor?"

He said, "Yes."

That amazed me, and I knew I was hearing God because that was not my answer. You probably know you are hearing God when it is not your answer.

This is what He said:

"Yes. Just because I cannot heal you, I take no pleasure in your suffering."

Hallelujah.

So if I cannot get God to heal me, what am I going to do? I am going to see if I can get a doctor to do it. But first I am going to make sure I cannot get God to do it, because I know how to get God to do it.

As Norvel Hayes would say, a better way to say that is, "I know how to line up with what God has said so He can do it." That is a better choice of words.

Notice again in verse 32:

But when we are judged, we are chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world.

When we are judged, we are chastened, corrected by the Lord, so we will not be condemned with the world and die before our time of everything the world is dying of.

Paul said, "For this cause many are sick." The issue here was not whether God heals. It was not whether it is His will to heal. The only thing Paul dealt with was why they were sick, not God's will in the matter.

I can tell you the cause he laid out: not rightly discerning the Lord's body.

For this cause many are sickly and sleep before their time. What cause? Not rightly discerning the Lord's body.

The way that has always been taught is that to discern the Lord's body is to recognize that healing is in the atonement. We know that. But what amazed me was that more people were healed when the power swept through the crowd this morning than are usually healed in a communion line.

If healing is in the atonement, why do more people get healed in a healing anointing than will probably be healed in this communion?

We have said that not discerning the Lord's body means failing to discern that this is His body, which was broken, and by His stripes we were healed. Since we did not recognize healing in the atonement, many were sick and died before their time.

But we do recognize healing in the atonement.

So what is Paul talking about?

At the beginning of this chapter, Paul talked about divisions and strife among them. He said, in effect, "Therefore, you are not taking the communion that the Lord Jesus Christ instituted."

Then Paul goes into the communion Jesus taught him. But he says, "You are full of strife and division, and you come in to take communion full of strife and division. It is not the communion table the Lord instituted that day."

Then he straightened the thing out.

After that he says, "Because you have done that, many are sick and dying before their time, because you are not rightly discerning the Lord's body."

If not rightly discerning the Lord's body means taking communion full of hatred, unforgiveness, and strife, then what is he talking about?

Look at Isaiah 53:4-6:

Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows: yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted.

But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed.

The actual rendering is this: the chastisement for our lack of peace was laid upon Him, and the form of punishment He received for our lack of peace was thirty-nine stripes.

You will find it in Deuteronomy 25. If there was a controversy between two men under the law, they would bring those two men before a righteous judge. The judge would hear both of their grievances against each other, and the one judged wrong would be made to lie down and take up

to thirty-nine lashes on his back.

Jesus, in fulfilling the law, stepped into my shoes. He stepped into my controversy as my substitute. He stepped into my hatred, my unforgiveness, my strife, and He was judged in my place by the righteous Judge, who is God.

Then He took the punishment I had coming: the full course of punishment prescribed by Jewish law, thirty-nine lashes.

So when Isaiah says the chastisement for our lack of peace was laid upon Him and by His stripes we are healed, those stripes were for my lack of peace, my strife, my unforgiveness, and my hatred. They were laid upon Him. With those stripes, in substitution for me, I was healed.

Hallelujah.

Let's talk about substitution and identification.

I want this whole group to stand up right here. Get at the end of the table and group up like a body. You are the body of Christ. That is it. Group up. You are the body of Christ.

Now I need another body.

Hallelujah. Turn loose of him.

He said, "For this cause many are sick and die before their time, not rightly discerning the Lord's body."

This group is a type of the spiritual body over here, which all of you and I belong to. We will let him play Jesus for a minute. You are dressed nicely.

He said, "Not rightly discerning the Lord's body." This is the spiritual body. This was the natural body of Jesus.

The chastisement for our lack of peace was laid upon Him, and with the stripes administered to Jesus' back, I was healed.

Healed from what? Lack of peace.

This natural body represented the spiritual body. When we take communion, we say:

 | This is His body, which was broken for me.

What does that mean?

He was made to lie down. He took the thirty-nine lashes on His back: the full course of punishment administered under the law for being judged wrong in a situation of strife, hatred, controversy, and breaking the law against another.

They broke His body with thirty-nine lashes, and later the crown of thorns and the spear in His side.

This was Jesus' natural body, but it was in substitution for the spiritual body. His natural body was broken by the whip so it might unite His spiritual body, which had been broken by controversy, strife, and hatred against each other.

In substitution, His natural body was broken to unite His spiritual body. The chastisement for our lack of peace was laid on Him. The thirty-nine lashes that broke His body, in substitution, broke His body so He might unite you as one, free from hatred, controversy, and strife.

This is why we only allow this bread to be broken in two so you can get to it. I may stop that and just have one fat loaf all the way to the end. You can only bake four feet of it at a time.

He said, "This is My body, which was broken for you."

Then He says, "This is My blood, which is shed for you."

This blood united you with the Father. This broken body unites us one with another.

When you reach up, rightly discerning the Lord's body, and tear this bread, it is a type of His natural body. When you tear it to pieces, you ought to understand that it is the body that broke through the stripes. By faith in those stripes, you can stand up and say:

The power of unforgiveness and hatred over me has been broken, because I boldly declare that by His stripes I am healed and united as one with every brother in the body of Christ.

When was I healed of disease? "Surely He has borne my sicknesses and carried my pains." We esteemed Him smitten, stricken of God.

Every sickness and disease known to mankind came upon Him so it would not have the power to come upon me. But when it came to His body, it was broken in substitution so I might be freed from the hatred, controversy, and strife that separates me from my brother.

For this cause many of you cannot get healed. You are sick all the time. You hurt all the time. If you would rightly discern the Lord's body and judge yourself, you would receive His correction and walk right out of it.

Let me tell you something: you cannot talk about men of God and people of God who love God. They might be deceived, and even in error, but if they love God, the only thing you are going to get for ill feelings against them is trouble.

So the great substitution and identification work is this: He was made to be sin for me, so that through the substitution of Himself in my sin I might be made the righteousness of God in Christ.

He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains, so that the penalty of disease administered in His body stripped disease of its right to judge me.

The chastisement for my lack of peace was laid upon Him in the form of thirty-nine lashes. With those stripes, in substitution for me, I have been healed.

As He stood before Pilate, being judged in your place, He refused to open His mouth and give any defense. Like a sheep before its shearers is dumb, He opened not His mouth.

Why? He was in the world, and the world was made by Him. He had the wisdom of the ages in Him. Why would He not defend Himself?

Very simple: because He was guilty.

He was not guilty by merit of acts. He was guilty because He stepped into your shoes. You were being judged, but He was being judged in your place. Therefore, He could not defend Himself.

So when the devil comes and tries to retry your case and judge you for what you have already been judged for, you can open your mouth and give him wisdom Jesus would not give. In your business dealings, every day when he comes to steal your money, you have the wisdom Jesus withheld in substitution freely available.

We have one more substitution to look at. Hallelujah.

I want to look at this because it set me free. I was grieving so hard. The only time I ever grieved harder was when I found out my boys in school had gotten on dope. My heart jumped up in my throat and got stuck. I could hardly talk. All I could do was cry.

Then some lifetime friendships were forming. People were becoming like brothers to me. Then they jumped up and found the place in my back where there was not already a knife.

When I make a friend, when I take you in all the way, you just about have to hit me in the head with a sledgehammer and say, "It is over."

After the devil burned me up a couple of times like that, I noticed an attitude building inside me that I was not going to let people on the inside anymore.

But when you do not let people on the inside, you cannot really help them.

I thought, "I am not going to be hurt again."

Let me tell you something: it is better to know people that closely and get hurt once in a while than never to know that level of friendship.

Jesus told me one time, "If you can boast of two or three lifelong friends--lifelong, the heavy kind, the kind who, if you got into trouble, would expend their fortune for you, the kind who would stay there right until you died--you have something precious."

I can tell you right now that if I were taken off this earth before my time, my wife, Daniel, and Tawn would not have to worry. They would not have to worry about being taken care of, because as long as my friends are alive, they will be well taken care of, and they know that.

If my friends were taken off this earth, their wives and families would never have to worry, not as long as I was alive.

If you never taste that closeness with the Lord--because that comes from Him--you are passing up the best this life has to offer.

Sometimes you feel like you are gambling by totally trusting people, and then they do things to you. But I found out that Jesus was betrayed in a degree I had never dreamed of.

He was betrayed by someone He called His trusted friend:

Mine own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, which did eat of my bread, hath lifted up his heel against me.

I had always envisioned Judas as hanging around the shadows of the campfire, never in the inner circle, not laughing, not fellowshiping.

Wrong.

He was as far in the inner circle as you could get. Jesus called him, "My trusted friend." His trusted friend who ate His bread lifted up his heel against Him.

Jesus was betrayed.

When this friend did this, I was hurting badly. Now I can let you in like that, because if you do rebel against it, Jesus has already taken the position you vacated.

That is one reason He says things like, "If any man come to Me and hate not his father, and mother, and wife, and children..." That word "hate" only means to love them less.

What He is promising you, when you love Him more than them, is the building material you need to see to your family's salvation.

He said to me, "If you hate your family--just love them more than Me--I cannot promise you the building material to see them through life. But if you love Me more, do you not know you will be manifesting My love to them too? You will not fall short in some area of the natural where you cannot help them, and I will not be absent because you chose them over Me."

The better friend He becomes to you, the better friend you can become to others.

Open to John 13. Jesus prophesied through David in Psalm 41:9:

Mine own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, which did eat of my bread, hath lifted up his heel against me.

I want to show you something as we prepare ourselves for forgiveness. I am not talking about the surface kind.

Listen to me: it is not a casual acquaintance who hurts you. The farther you let a person in, the bigger vacuum they are liable to leave, especially if they betray you. And yet the best life has to offer is in those kinds of friendships, because you will find people like you who will not betray you. Then you have the best this life has.

When was the last time you heard foot washing taught on? How many have heard it taught on besides here at the Prayer Center by me in the last five years? In the last three years? In the last two?

As you can see, it is not as popular as communion. But Jesus taught on it, so what does it mean?

Let's go through it quickly and get your hearts ready for communion.

When Jesus came into my office and ministered to me, He gave me one of those mini-visions you see inside. He so healed me that day.

My wife, Rosalie, had warned me several times. She said, "You know this person is going to do you wrong."

I said, "I do not care."

She said, "I am just warning you."

I said, "I do not care. They are never going to do it."

She said, "I know it, but..."

I said, "I do not care."

Why? Because when Jesus becomes your everything, and someone vacates a place in your life, He has already filled it.

Are you ready?

John 13:1:

Now before the feast of the passover, when Jesus knew that his hour was come that he should depart out of this world unto the Father, having loved his own which were in the world, he loved them unto the end.

Now He was beginning this portion of a substitution and identification walk as He moved toward the cross.

Verse 2:

And supper being ended, the devil having now put into the heart of Judas Iscariot, Simon's son, to betray him;

Jesus knowing that the Father had given all things into his hands, and that he was come from God, and went to God;

He riseth from supper, and laid aside his garments; and took a towel, and girded himself.

The towel would hang down so He could dry the feet after He washed them.

How would you like to have gone down in history as one of the twelve whose feet He washed? We are talking about the Son of God.

Verse 5:

After that he poureth water into a basin, and began to wash the disciples' feet, and to wipe them with the towel wherewith he was girded.

Then cometh he to Simon Peter: and Peter saith unto him, Lord, dost thou wash my feet?

Jesus answered and said unto him, What I do thou knowest not now; but thou shalt know hereafter.

Peter saith unto him, Thou shalt never wash my feet.

Jesus answered him, If I wash thee not, thou hast no part with me.

That statement let me know foot washing had something to do with redemption and the substitution and identification we have with Jesus. That is a very strong statement: "If you will not let Me wash your feet, you will have no part with Me."

I am sure Peter reacted the same way many of you would have reacted:

Lord, not my feet only, but also my hands and my head.

In other words, "Throw me off Niagara Falls."

They thought Jesus was talking about the custom of the day. Travelers came in from dusty, muddy roads wearing sandals, and if the household had servants, the servants would come and wash the dirt off their feet in a basin of water.

Peter was thinking, "I am the servant, not You. Please, You cannot wash my feet."

But Jesus made a redemptive statement: "If you do not let Me wash your feet, you will have no part with Me."

That made me want to understand foot washing. I was in the back room grieving and hurt, reading through John, because John taught on love. I do not know how many times I had read through it, and the Lord would not let me off this thirteenth chapter. I stopped right there, and as I meditated

on it over and over, this vision came. It cleared the whole chapter up for me.

Look again at verse 9:

Simon Peter saith unto him, Lord, not my feet only, but also my hands and my head.
Jesus saith to him, He that is washed needeth not save to wash his feet, but is clean every whit: and ye are clean, but not all.

In reference to the custom, Jesus said that a traveler who was already washed only needed his feet washed. He was clean. But then Jesus added, "You are clean, but not all."

That "not all" was a reference to Judas.

You might as well know at this point that when Jesus got down on His knees in front of the man who was about to betray Him, He knew Judas was going to betray Him.

"My trusted friend who ate My bread has lifted up his heel against Me." That meant every step Judas took away from Him was to do Him harm.

In reference to the custom, Jesus said, "You are clean, but not all." He was positioning Himself to wash the filth of betrayal off Judas' feet.

One more time: it is not casual friends who have the power to hurt you deeply.

Verse 10 says:

He that is washed needeth not save to wash his feet, but is clean every whit: and ye are clean, but not all.

This was not merely about the custom.

Verse 11:

For he knew who should betray him; therefore said he, Ye are not all clean.

After He had washed their feet, taken His garments, and sat down again, He said:

Know ye what I have done to you?
Ye call me Master and Lord: and ye say well; for so I am.
If I then, your Lord and Master, have washed your feet; ye also ought to wash one another's feet.

In other words, "If I, in a supreme act of forgiveness, washed the filth of betrayal off Judas' feet--if I, your Lord, Master, and example, totally forgave him--what should you be doing to one another?"

Verse 15:

For I have given you an example, that ye should do as I have done to you.

Then He says:

Verily, verily, I say unto you, The servant is not greater than his lord; neither he that is sent greater than he that sent him.

Jesus is saying, "My Father is greater than I am, and I am your Lord and Master. The servant is not greater than the Master who sent him, and I was sent by the Father. I am your Lord and Master; yet if I, your example, wash your feet and you will not wash each other's feet, then you have exalted yourself higher than God."

Let that sink in.

If He, your Lord and Master, in a supreme act of forgiveness, washed the filth of betrayal off Judas' feet, then you, as the servant, should forgive even more.

This gets very interesting.

Verse 17:

If ye know these things, happy are ye if ye do them.

Is that not an incredible statement? That is what snagged me in the chapter.

Happy if I do what things? Wash people's feet.

He said, "If you know these things, happy are you if you do them."

Let me tell you what happiness is. Happiness is a fruit of joy. Joy is a fruit of the Spirit. You can throw me in prison, and I will have great joy. I may not be very happy about it, but I can have great joy because joy is a fruit of the Spirit, whereas happiness is generally a fruit of circumstances.

A man who is very happy is a man in whom the fruit of joy manifests itself in happiness.

Jesus is telling us something: happy is the man who not only knows these things, but does them.

Why would I be happy? Because there is nothing the devil can do to defeat a man who will walk in that kind of forgiveness. Therefore, you will be getting victory all the time, and that is where the happiness comes from.

I like the example of Paul when he was bound in the Tullian Keep, the prison in Rome hewn out of solid rock where the sewer system was tapped into it. He was tied waist deep in human waste. Because he was a Roman citizen, if he received mail, they had to untie his hands. His hands were tied to a column.

Peter did not have that right, but Paul was a Roman citizen, so he had the right to receive and answer mail. It was in that condition that he received the courier from the Philippian church.

I do not say they brought him a candle. They had to untie his hands to get the blood flowing again. That is where he wrote the book of Philippians from.

So when he says, "I count all things but dung that I may win Christ," he was talking more literally than you might believe.

I like the part in Philippians where he said, "Do all things without murmurings." Some people do not have air conditioning in their car, so they cannot come in the morning.

Jesus said the man who knows these things is happy if he does them, because when you walk in that kind of forgiveness, you will continually overcome your circumstances. Any disease, anything that tries to take your joy down--if it cannot take your joy, eventually your joy is going to manifest again and again in happiness, which is the fruit of circumstances.

Hallelujah.

Verse 18:

I speak not of you all: I know whom I have chosen: but that the scripture may be fulfilled, He that eateth bread with me hath lifted up his heel against me.

Now I tell you before it come, that, when it is come to pass, ye may believe that I am he.

Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that receiveth whomsoever I send receiveth me; and he that receiveth me receiveth him that sent me.

There I was in my office, grieving. I could not believe what had happened. It has happened several times since, but Jesus has already filled the capacity.

I am not going to stop loving people. I am just not going to do it.

You are not my problem. My battle is not with flesh and blood, but against principalities and powers. If you are hurting people, it is because you are a pawn in somebody else's hands. I do not recognize you as my problem, nor do I hold you responsible.

So if you have something against me, why? What is wrong with prayer? Because you have to whip out a little bit? Because God wants to drive you the extra mile toward revival so many more people will be saved because you lived? Because of our worship? Because we teach too much on the very principles that, if you will do them, will change your life for good?

Why do you not like us? Check your flesh. Get your checklist out.

"Well, you will not let me do anything."

Have you ever thought that maybe you are not ready to do something? You get in a huff and leave about every six months. Who can trust you?

I was hurting badly. Suddenly I slipped into the Spirit and had one of those kinds of visions. If you want to understand God's voice, get the series we did a few months ago on hearing God's voice.

Inside my spirit, a vision materialized, and I can tell the difference. It stays right there. It does not change with my thoughts. I can see through it, but it stays there.

I saw Jesus on His knees in front of a man, looking very intently up into his face as He was washing his feet. I will never forget the look of compassion on His face.

What is so unusual about the vision is that if you asked me what He looked like, I could hardly tell you. Yet I could see what represented a look of compassion like you would not believe.

He washed the filth of betrayal off Judas' feet.

Why?

Because Judas was about to betray Jesus into the Romans' hands. He was going to betray Him, but do not be too mad at Judas. Jesus was beginning His walk of substitution and identification. He was going to be betrayed, and under the penalty of that betrayal, He was going to go to the cross and die.

He was betrayed because Jesus took your place. Because He took your place, He was your substitute. As your substitute, He was guilty. So when Judas betrayed Him, He was guilty to be crucified in your place.

This is what Jesus wanted to get over to me:

"I, your Lord and Master, washed the filth of betrayal off this man's feet, and then I went and died under the penalty of it. He betrayed Me. I died under the penalty of that betrayal. Now son, if you follow My example, you are going to be happy."

Because every person, in the spirit, whose feet you wash of the filth of betrayal--all the harm they meant for you, all the destruction they meant for you, all the bad words they are going to say about you--because you washed the filth of betrayal off their feet, all of it is going to pass over you and come to rest upon Jesus, having been paid in full by that penalty.

If you hold out against them, then the penalty He suffered in your place to free you is not going to work. But if you forgive them, then all the harm they meant for you will have already been carried out in Jesus in His betrayal, and you go free.

"But you do not know what they are doing to me."

It does not matter. It was all taken out on Jesus under the betrayal. If you wash that filth off their feet, you go free.

So I maintain: you are not my problem.

If you wrestle with flesh and blood, you still are not my problem.

"But I am going to hurt you."

You are still not my problem. You are answering to your master. You are caught in the crossfire. I am going to help you.

Just as communion is an outward manifestation of an inward work, foot washing is an outward manifestation of an inward work. It was actually part of communion.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

If we ever have foot washing, the main thing is to attain to it in the Spirit. But if we ever have it outwardly, do not worry. We will warn you ahead of time so you can paint your toenails.

Some of you need to wash your feet, get those snags off, and soak them in oil for a while. I am only kidding, of course.

But this is not casual ground. Jesus said to Peter, "If I do not wash you, you will have no part with Me."

That is serious ground.

If you do not partake of this part of My redemption, you will have no part with Me.

Peter, you have to forgive. You have got to forgive.